

Making agent behavior understandable

A debugging experience built into how creators build agents

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[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 01] Figma frame: final trace view in agent builder Use the strongest full-width screen.

I helped design agent observability for Agent Builder: a way for creators to see what their agent actually did at each step, catch failures, and fix them without leaving the place where they build. The work shipped as an integrated debug mode with a step-by-step trace view, first for task-based agents and then for conversational agents.

Shipped April–June 2025 as part of Agent Builder, from early design through GA of debug mode across customer environments. ([Agent Observability roadmap and backlog - June 2025](#))

Team

· Seema Jethani, Product · Neil Dhruva, Product · Megha Jhunjunwala, Engineering · Yuxing Zhou, Engineering · Andy Welfle, Content Design · Neel Saswade, Designer

The problem: agents were a black box

Creators could build an agent but had no reliable way to see why it behaved the way it did. When a run went wrong, the failure was buried in backend traces meant for engineers, not builders. ([Agent observability designs](#))

The design needed to serve both technical and non-technical creators without turning debugging into an engineering task. ([Agent observability naming](#))

[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 02] Figma frame: before state, raw trace vs. builder need Make the gap obvious.

A trace view for steps, not latency

I designed a trace view that shows the agent's steps in sequence, with input, output, and execution detail for each one. The first design used accordions per step. Feedback pushed toward less chunky, more contextual presentation. ([Agent observability designs](#))

We chose a step-by-step input/output view over a Langfuse-style timeline, since a timeline mostly helps latency debugging and creators here were reasoning about behavior. ([Agent observability designs](#))

[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 03] Figma frame: trace view step detail Show a step expanded with input, output, and metadata.

Debugging inside preview, not a separate trace URL

The revised design moved debugging information directly into preview mode, so creators debug in the same place they test. I added a search bar for variables and cleaned up how text data reads. ([Agent observability designs](#))

The product deliberately moved away from a separate trace URL toward an integrated experience in the main UI. ([Agent observability designs](#))

[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 04] Figma frame: debug mode integrated in preview Show the toggle and the in-context debug panel.

Language that both audiences understand

Working with content design, we pressure-tested the term "trace view" and the surrounding labels so the interface stayed clear for people who had never seen a trace before. We added affordances to signal when a creator was in debug mode and how to move through it. ([Agent observability naming](#))

[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 05] Figma frame: mode affordance and labels Show the banner or status treatment.

The impact

Debug mode reached GA for task-based agents across customer environments, and conversational-agent debugging followed, stitching tracing across multiple runs of a single conversation. ([Agent Observability roadmap and backlog - June 2025](#))

The MVP scoped tightly on UI and data presentation, deferring chronological sorting and timeline views so creators got a usable debugging surface sooner. ([Agent observability designs](#))

[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 06] Figma frame: GA trace view in a real agent Use one strong final shipped screen.

What comes next

With a stable trace foundation, the next phase moves from reading failures to acting on them: streaming traces live, per-step feedback, comparing runs, and recommendations when an agent drifts from its goal. There is also a path toward pro-code creators through API access to trace data. ([Agent Observability roadmap and backlog - June 2025](#))

[IMAGE PLACEHOLDER 07] Figma frame: future observability exploration Label this clearly as future-facing work.

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